

about 3,000 words

Water Gap Before Dawn

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

My boots were already wet when the gravel gave under the first switchback.

I ran with my right hand flat on the sealed envelope in my jacket pocket and my left hand grabbing at wet mountain laurel that tore and left a sharp green smell on my palm. The Delaware sat black below us in the Gap, a cold strip between Pennsylvania rock and the New Jersey wall of Mount Tammany, and the interstate lights on the far side made a thin orange line that did not help. First light was still a rumor over the ridge. My name is Micah Orth. I was nineteen that morning. Devon ran three steps behind me and cursed every time his heel slid on the white quartz gravel the trail crews leave like salt on a winter road.

We had come up from River Road with a man behind us who used to pump gas at the station by the interstate exit, a man named Kerr who used to wipe his hands on a red rag and talk about steelhead when the river ran right. What followed us now wore Kerr's work coat and Kerr's boots, and the boots hit the gravel wrong, as if the ankles inside them had learned a different

animal. The smell that came with him was river silt and burned copper wire. He did not call our names. He breathed like a bellows with a tear in it.

"Keep going," Devon said. "Lake Lenape lot. Your aunt's car. We drive."

"He was between us and the lot," I said. "We go up."

Up meant the white blazes of the Appalachian Trail climbing Mount Minsi on the Pennsylvania side, switchbacks cut into sandstone and conglomerate, roots like trip wires in the dark. I knew the first overlooks from daytime hikes: Council Rock where you can see the river bend and the interstate across it, Lookout Rock farther on where Tammany fills the view and the Gap opens like a cut throat. I did not know them at four in the morning with a changed man on our heels and a sealed word from my grandmother pressing a rectangle into my ribs.

Grandma Ruth had put the envelope in my hand three nights before, in her kitchen in Stroudsburg, under a fluorescent tube that hummed. The paper was thick. A strip of clear packing tape sealed the flap twice over. On the front, in her block print, she had written my name and a hard instruction: MICAH. OPEN WHEN YOU NEED IT. NOT BEFORE.

"What is it," I had asked.

"A word that works," she said. "Armor speech. Keep it dry. Keep it shut until your hands decide they are out of other tools."

I had put it in my jacket and gone to the Gap with Devon for a stupid reason: he wanted photographs of the overlooks before sunrise for a class, and I owed him a ride because he had fixed my alternator with a wrench and a lot of bad language. We parked on River Road near the borough, walked the cold streets toward the trailhead by Lake Lenape, and found Kerr standing under a sodium lamp by the empty pumps of the closed station, coat open, head tipped as if he were listening to a frequency our ears did not own.

Devon raised his camera. Kerr's face turned toward us, and the face was Kerr's and was not. The eyes held too steady. The mouth opened on a sound that was not a greeting. We ran. He came after us with that wrong gait, and the sealed envelope rode in my pocket like a small brick.

Now the trail climbed. My lungs burned cold air. A plastic bottle cap lay white in the gravel under a blaze post, and I nearly twisted an ankle on it and kept going. Devon's camera strap slapped his chest. Behind us, boots scraped rock in a rhythm that did not match a man's stride. Branches broke. A wood thrush woke early and shut up again.

"What does he want," Devon said.

"The envelope," I said.

"Open it."

I kept my mouth shut. The urge to tear the tape and read by phone light sat in my fingers and I refused it.

We hit the first hard switchback where the trail cuts left and the river drops farther below. Ice filmed the shaded stone. My boot sole squealed. Devon grabbed a root and swung past me, breath loud. Kerr took the corner below us without slowing. In the thin light I saw his coat hang wrong on one shoulder, as if the joint under it had slipped and then set in a new place. He lifted his head and the smell of burned copper rolled up the grade.

Devon said a word his mother hates and put on speed.

Council Rock came as a gray shelf on our right, open enough that the Gap wind hit my face full of river cold and distant truck noise from I-80. I did not stop for the view. Tammany's dark mass sat across the water like a sleeping animal. Kerr's boots hit the shelf behind us while we were still on it. Gravel sprayed. Devon's camera swung and cracked against a boulder hard enough that the lens hood popped off and skittered toward the drop. He did not go after it.

"Leave it," I said, and we ran again into the trees where the trail narrowed between mountain laurel and oak that still held last year's leaves in fists. White blazes showed as pale rectangles when my phone light swept them. I kept the light off most of the time to save the battery and because a moving beam is a flag. Kerr did not need a beam. He tracked us by sound and by whatever the thinning veil had given him in place of ordinary sight.

A side chute of loose talus opened left of the main trail, a scar of rock where water had stripped the soil. Devon took the main path. I turned my head and saw Kerr close enough that his coat buttons showed, dull metal. He reached with a hand whose fingers were too long for the glove still hanging from one wrist like a forgotten rag. I cut left into the talus because the main trail was a funnel and funnels favor the stronger pursuer.

Stone slid. My palms went raw on the cold rock. The envelope corner stabbed my side through the jacket. Far below, the Delaware made a low continuous sound against the Gap walls, and a single truck jake-brake barked on the interstate and then faded. Behind me Kerr entered the chute and the loose rock under him moved in a sheet, and he rode it the way a man rides a bad ladder, knees wrong, coat flapping. He made a sound then that had consonants in it and no mercy.

"Micah," Devon yelled from the trail above. "This way."

I clawed up to the blazed path and Devon hauled on my sleeve, and we ran again with my right palm bleeding onto the jacket zipper while first light still refused the ridge and the Gap held its dark like a held breath.

Lookout Rock is where most day hikers stop and take the photograph that makes Tammany look close enough to touch. We reached the open stone with our legs shaking and our mouths open on cold air. The overlook dropped toward the river bend. Wind shoved at my ears.

Across the Gap, a single set of headlights crawled the New Jersey road like a slow insect. Devon put his hands on his knees and spat. I put my back to a boulder and dug the envelope out.

Kerr came onto the rock twenty yards below us, climbing the last pitch on all fours for a stretch, then upright again. Up close the wrongness was clearer. His neck turned farther than a neck should. His work coat was the same red-and-gray square pattern I had seen at the pumps for two summers, but the chest under it rose and fell on a rhythm that did not match fear or effort. He stopped at the edge of the open stone and tipped his head.

"Give it," he said. The voice was Kerr's station voice sandpapered down to a rasp. "The sealed word. She put a Name in paper. Paper burns. Names do other work."

Devon straightened. "Who told you that."

Kerr's mouth pulled. "The ones who taught me to listen after the pumps closed. The veil thins before dawn on this ridge. I used to be a man who wiped windshields. I am still wearing him. Hand over the scrap and you walk down to River Road on your own feet."

My thumb found the tape edge on the envelope. Grandma Ruth's block print faced me in the gray: OPEN WHEN YOU NEED IT. NOT BEFORE.

Devon's eyes went to my hands. "If it's a prayer, say it. If it's a joke, we throw it and run for the fire road."

Lake Road / the old fire road runs wider and kinder than the AT in places, a way down toward the lot if you know the junctions. We did not have clean minutes for map work. Kerr took one step onto the overlook stone. The burned-copper smell thickened. My stomach turned once and settled into a hard knot.

I tore the tape.

The flap gave. Inside lay a single folded scrap of notebook paper, the kind with blue lines and a red margin, creased twice. I unfolded it with fingers that shook from cold and from the run. Grandma Ruth's block print sat centered on the blue lines in one word large enough to read in bad light: JESUS. Under that, in smaller letters, she had written the work order she used when the dark pressed a house, four short commands on one line: Armor on, lance out, speak and stand. The page held no sermon and no long chapter and verse, only a Name and a work order small enough to fit in a palm.

Kerr's breath hitched. He came forward faster, coat flapping, boots loud on stone. Devon moved left as if to block. Kerr backhanded him without looking, a sweep that caught Devon's shoulder and put him down hard on the rock. The camera skidded away across stone. Devon rolled and stayed low, swearing through his teeth, alive.

I held the scrap in both hands.

Grandma Ruth had called it armor speech. Pastor Mel at her church had talked once about prayer as a tool you pick up when the dark presses, the same way you pick up a wrench. I had sat in that pew and checked my phone under the hymnal. Tonight the dark pressed with a body and a smell and a wrong gait, and the paper was warm from my pocket.

I spoke the Name out loud, then spoke the rest the way you speak a clear order to a stuck bolt when your uncle is watching and the truck has to move.

"Armor on, lance out. In Jesus' name, hold what I cannot see. Amen."

I did not preach at Kerr. The scrap went flat to my chest under my left palm over the jacket zipper, and my right hand stayed free. The words went out of my mouth into the Gap wind and did not come back as echo. They went forward the way a thrown tool goes forward when you mean it to land.

Kerr stopped as if he had hit a wire.

His boots scraped. His head jerked sideways. The burned-copper smell flared and then thinned, the way a bad electrical smell thins when you kill a breaker. He made that bellows sound again, torn, and took one more step that did not gain ground. His eyes, too steady a moment before, flickered like a man fighting sleep.

Devon got to one knee. "Micah."

I kept the scrap pressed to my chest. My mouth stayed on the Name under my breath, short and plain, the way Grandma Ruth's people name a Helper when the dark tries to take the air out of a room. I had never done it on a rock over a river with a changed man in a gas-station coat. My knees wanted to fold. My hands stayed.

Kerr's glove-dangling wrist lifted toward me and then dropped. He spoke once more, quieter.

"She taught you to throw," he said. "The old Kerr would have laughed. This Kerr cannot cross that line while you hold it."

He backed off the overlook stone onto the trail gravel. His coat hung on the wrong shoulder. For a long breath he stood in the white-blaze path with the Gap wind pushing at him, and then he turned downhill toward River Road and the pumps and whatever listening post had remade him. His gait stayed wrong and his speed stayed more than a tired man's as he went, and he did not look back.

We listened until the scrape of his boots faded under the interstate hum.

Devon stood all the way up. His shoulder would bruise purple by lunch. Devon picked up his camera and found the lens cracked in a hairline across the glass. The camera stayed in his hands. He hung it on his neck by the strap and stared at the scrap still flat under my palm.

"You going to explain that," he said.

"Not with a speech," I said. "Grandma gave me a sealed word. I opened it when I needed it. I spoke what she wrote. He stopped."

"I saw him stop," Devon said. "I also saw a man who used to sell me chips at midnight turn into a problem that belongs in a movie. I am not joining your aunt's church because a piece of paper got loud on a rock."

"I know," I said.

Mute sat between us for a stretch of wind. Devon's jaw worked. He wanted an argument that would put the morning back into a box labeled adrenaline and bad light. I did not give him the argument he wanted.

We took the trail down carefully, watching the switchbacks for a red-and-gray coat that did not reappear. At Council Rock the sky had gone from black to a thin steel blue. A freight horn sounded somewhere downriver. My palm had stopped bleeding and stuck to the scrap with dried blood in a small map of the run. I folded the paper again, Name inward, and slid it back into the torn envelope, then into the pocket.

Near Lake Lenape the fire road met the lot in ordinary gray morning. Aunt June's car sat where I had left it, dew on the windshield, a parking stub on the dash from a different day. No Kerr at the pumps. The station windows held their closed signs. A delivery truck rolled past on the road toward the borough with its lights still on and its driver yawning behind the glass.

Devon rode shotgun with his cracked camera in his lap and did not turn the radio on. I drove us toward Stroudsburg with the heat on low and my wet boots drying against the pedals. At Grandma Ruth's kitchen the fluorescent tube still hummed. She took one look at my palm and the envelope and put a dish towel under my hand.

"You opened it," she said.

"On Lookout Rock," I said. "He wanted it. I spoke it. He could not cross while I held it."

She poured coffee that had sat on the warmer too long and set the mug where I could reach it with my clean hand. "Armor is for wearing. A lance is for throwing. Paper is only the reminder. The Name does the work."

Devon stood by the door with his jacket still zipped and shook his head once, done talking for the morning.

"I'll grant the stop," he said. "I won't grant the metaphysics before breakfast. Micah, text me when your hand's cleaned up. I need a new lens and a story I can turn in that does not mention veil thinning."

Devon left, and the screen door slapped behind him. Grandma Ruth washed the blood out of the scrap's corner under cold water without scrubbing the ink away, then laid the paper flat on a plate to dry. The Name and the four short commands held their ink under the kitchen light.

I am twenty-three now. I still hike Minsi in daylight. Council Rock still shows the river bend and the interstate. Lookout Rock still frames Tammany. The bottle cap is gone from the trail. Kerr's pumps changed ownership and the new night man does not know the name. Devon got his class credit with photographs taken on a different ridge on a different morning, and he still sits across from me at a diner on Main and argues that prayer is a noise brave people make when the body runs out of options. He will grant the stop on the rock. He will not grant a Person on the other end of Grandma Ruth's block print.

I keep the scrap in a sandwich bag in the glove box of the car I drive now. The envelope's tape is long gone. On mornings when the Gap wind comes through town smelling of river and

wet stone, I check that the bag is still there the way some people check a spare tire. I do not open it for show. I do not preach it at Devon. When I need it, my hands know the fold.

If you ever run the switchbacks on the Pennsylvania side before first light and hear boots that hit gravel wrong behind you, check your pocket for the sealed scrap a trusted person put there. The veil along the Water Gap thins in the cold hour. The scrap still fits in a palm.

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